



CTI GROUP

PARTICIPANT REFERENCE GUIDE

Interview Readiness Prep Packet

Strategic preparation for your U.S. Embassy or Consulate interview. J-1 Exchange Visitor Program — Intern and Trainee categories.

DOCUMENT

CTI-GUIDE-J1-INT

VERSION

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EFFECTIVE

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This packet is a Participant-side reference. It is not a script. Always answer consular officers truthfully and in your own words. Issued by CTI Group Worldwide Services, Inc. under CTI-SOP-J1-004 (Pre-Departure Orientation and Interview Readiness).

1 WELCOME AND HOW TO USE THIS PACKET

READ THIS FIRST

This packet helps you walk into your consular interview **prepared, calm, and honest**. It is not a script. You are never asked to memorize answers. Your interview will go well when you can explain — in your own words — what you are doing, why, and that you intend to return home when your program ends.

! ALWAYS TELL THE TRUTH

Consular officers are highly experienced at detecting rehearsed or misleading answers. Any material misrepresentation in a U.S. visa interview can result in a lifetime bar from the United States. CTI's rule is simple: **answer every question truthfully, completely, and in your own words.**

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Everything you say in your interview should reflect one core idea. If you remember nothing else from this packet, remember this:

"I am coming to the United States as an Exchange Visitor to participate in a structured J-1 program."

**CULTURAL
EXCHANGE**

Not an employment visa.

TEMPORARY

Intent to return home.

SKILLED

Focused on training.

PROFESSIONAL

Skill acquisition only.

★ **USE THE RIGHT LANGUAGE**

Refer to your placement as a **training program**, not a job. Refer to the U.S. organization as your **Host Company**, not your employer. Refer to what you receive as a **stipend, training allowance, or compensation**, not as salary or wages. This is not a word game — it reflects what the program legally is: a cultural exchange under the Mutual Educational and Cultural Exchange Act of 1961.

YOUR PROGRAM AT A GLANCE

Be ready to speak clearly about each item below. Specific is better than general.

WHO

YOUR SPONSOR

The U.S. Department of State—designated organization that issues your DS-2019. CTI works with three sponsors: **CIEE, Alliance Abroad (AAG), and Greenheart**. Know which one is on your DS-2019.

WHERE

YOUR HOST COMPANY

The U.S. organization where your training placement happens. Know the legal name, the city and state, your role, your department, and your supervisor.

WHAT

TRAINING PLAN

The DS-7002 sets out what you will learn, who supervises you, and the duration. Be ready to summarize day-to-day activities in your own words.

■ INTERN VS. TRAINEE CATEGORY

I INTERN TRACK

Current student or graduated within last 12 months. Program max: **12 months**. Focus on educational supplement bridging study and practice.

I TRAINEE TRACK

Degree + 1 year experience, OR 5 years total field experience. Program max: **18 months** (12 for hospitality). Focus on advanced skills.

🏠 212(E) RULE

Check if you are subject to the **2-Year Home Residency Requirement** based on your country's Skills List or government funding. This will be indicated on your DS-2019. If subject, you must return home for two years before applying for certain other U.S. visas.

INTERVIEW DAY SEQUENCE

U.S. visa interviews are short — typically **2-3 minutes**, with the officer asking **3-6 questions**. The officer makes a quick, professional judgment based on your documents, your answers, and your demeanor.

THE FIVE-STEP SEQUENCE

STEP 1**ARRIVE**

Security; no electronics. Arrive 15-30 min early.

STEP 2**VERIFY**

Documents scanned at window. Appointment confirmed.

STEP 3**BIOMETRIC**

Digital fingerprints. Follow staff instructions exactly.

STEP 4**INTERVIEW**

Officer window. 3-6 questions. 2-3 minutes typical.

STEP 5**DECISION**

Approval or refusal communicated on the spot.

✓ THE "DO" LIST

- Dress in professional attire.
- Arrive 15-30 minutes early.
- Answer honestly and briefly.
- Maintain direct eye contact.
- Listen to each question fully before answering.
- Hand over documents only when asked.
- Thank the officer at the end.

× THE "DON'T" LIST

- Bring phones or electronics into the embassy.
- Recite memorized scripts.
- Argue with the officer or interrupt.
- Signal long-term U.S. stay or settlement intent.
- Volunteer information that was not asked.
- Speak negatively about your home country.
- Pretend to know something you do not know.

I CITIZENSHIP NOTE

Canadian citizens enter directly at U.S. ports with a DS-2019. No visa stamp is required.

CONSULAR Q&A PREPARATION

The eight questions below cover what officers most commonly ask. **These are not scripts.** Practice answering each out loud in your own words. The typical interview lasts only **2-3 minutes**.

Q Why do you want to train in the U.S.?

→ State that you are participating in the J-1 Exchange Visitor Program (Intern or Trainee), what you will be training in, and what you hope to learn. Keep it specific and short.

Q Who is your Host and what do they do?

→ Name your Host Company by its legal name, the city and state, the industry, and what your department does. Briefly describe your supervisor's role.

Q Describe your Training Phase specifics.

→ Summarize what your DS-7002 says you will learn — the key skills, the rotation if there is one, the supervision structure. Day-to-day activities in your own words.

Q How does this boost your career at home?

→ Explain how the training fits the work or studies you are doing now and what you plan to do when you return home. Specific is better than general.

Q Who is funding your relocation?

→ Be honest about how the program is funded — your own savings, your family, scholarships, or a combination. Know roughly how much the program costs.

Q What are your plans after J-1 ends?

→ Speak about your specific plans in Indonesia after the program: continuing studies, returning to a role, joining the family business, applying skills learned in the U.S.

Q Why must you return to your country?

→ Your "home-country ties" are the answer — see Section 6 next. Be ready to talk about education, employment, family, and other anchors that pull you home.

Q List your family ties and assets.

→ Parents, spouse, children, property, bank accounts, family business. Tangible ties that show your life is rooted in Indonesia.

★ PRACTICE OUT LOUD

Practice these eight questions out loud — with a friend, a mirror, or your CTI Coordinator. Don't write answers down. Don't memorize phrases. The goal is to be able to answer naturally, in your own words, within the 2-3 minute interview window.

EVIDENCE OF HOME-COUNTRY TIES

Officers assume immigrant intent until you prove otherwise. Your job is to **evidence your bonds** to Indonesia clearly and specifically. The six anchor categories below cover what officers look for.

ANCHOR 1

FAMILY

Parents, spouse, or children waiting for you in Indonesia.

ANCHOR 2

CAREER

Specific firms or roles you will join at home. Letters of intent count.

ANCHOR 3

EDUCATION

Ongoing studies, thesis completion, or post-graduate program awaiting you.

ANCHOR 4

PROPERTY

Real estate, leases, or bank accounts in your name in Indonesia.

ANCHOR 5

RELEVANCE

Local demand for your new U.S. skills back home.

ANCHOR 6

SOCIAL

Community roles and long-term commitments in your home community.

I MATCH YOUR STORY TO YOUR FILE

Every Anchor you mention in your interview should match the documentation in your CTI file. Your CTI Coordinator has reviewed your Return-Intent Assessment with you. **If you are unsure what is documented in your file, ask your Coordinator before the interview.**

! NEVER INVENT ANCHORS

Do not claim ties you do not have. Do not "borrow" anchors from another Participant's situation. Inventing a job offer, fabricating property ownership, or exaggerating family obligations is a material misrepresentation under U.S. immigration law and is a permanent bar from CTI placement.

Officers will assess whether you have the funds to support yourself in the U.S. without needing unauthorized work. Be ready to show how you will cover relocation and the first weeks of living costs.

TYPICAL STARTUP COSTS (USD)

EXPENSE ITEM	ESTIMATED (USD)
Deposit & 1st Month Rent	\$1,500 – \$3,000
Initial Groceries / Household Setup	\$400 – \$800
Local Transport / SIM Card	\$100 – \$300
Emergency Reserve	\$1,000+

ACCEPTED EVIDENCE

- **Bank statements** — last 6 months.
- **Sponsor affidavit** — if family or relatives are funding your trip.
- **Host stipend or salary letter** — confirming the compensation you will receive during the program.

! WEAK FINANCE IS A DENIAL RED FLAG

If you cannot demonstrate how you will cover relocation costs without taking on unauthorized work, the officer will deny your visa. Bring bank statements organized and current.

CRITICAL DENIAL RED FLAGS

The four categories below are the most common reasons J-1 visas are denied. Read each carefully — these are the failure modes you need to avoid.

RED FLAG 1

PERMANENT INTENT

Expressing any desire to live, work long-term, or find a spouse in the U.S. — even casually. Officers are trained to detect this.

RED FLAG 2

CONTRADICTION

Verbal answers that conflict with your DS-160, your DS-2019, your DS-7002, or your social media history.

RED FLAG 3

VAGUE TRAINING

Not knowing exactly what skills or software you will gain, or who your supervisor is, or what your day-to-day looks like.

RED FLAG 4

WEAK FINANCE

Failure to prove you can cover relocation costs without needing unauthorized second jobs in the U.S.

! THE COMMON THREAD

All four red flags point to the same officer question: **"Is this person really here for a structured, temporary training program — or are they coming to settle, work informally, or stay long-term?"** Your job in the interview is to answer that question clearly with your words, your documents, and your demeanor.

U.S. consular officers are required to audit your digital footprint as part of the visa adjudication process. The 2025 Digital Mandate sets out three mandatory transparency rules and one critical integrity rule.

MANDATORY TRANSPARENCY RULES

RULE 1

SET TO PUBLIC

Your social media profiles must be set to public at least **72 hours before your interview**.

RULE 2

FULL DISCLOSURE

Every social media handle you have used in the last **5 years** must be disclosed on your DS-160.

RULE 3

VETTING SCOPE

Officers audit your activity for anti-U.S. sentiment or any intent inconsistencies with your stated purpose.

MAINTAINING DIGITAL INTEGRITY

⊘ MASS DELETION PROHIBITED

Sudden account deletions or significant activity removals right before your interview are **strictly flagged as suspicious**. They are often construed as attempts to conceal inadmissible history or immigrant intent. Mass deletion can be worse than the content itself.

Best Practices

- **Audit, Don't Delete:** Ensure professional alignment on LinkedIn and Facebook. Review your public content carefully but don't engage in mass removal.
- **Persistence:** Keep your settings public until the visa is in your possession.
- **Identity:** Your profile data must match your DS-160 exactly — same name spelling, same date of birth, same employment history.

! CTI NEVER ASKS FOR YOUR PASSWORD

CTI reviews public content only. CTI **never** requests, collects, or stores your social media passwords. If anyone — a CTI recruiter, a partner, or a third party — asks for your password, refuse and report it immediately to compliance@cti-usa.com.

Under the William Wilberforce Trafficking Victims Protection Reauthorization Act, consular officers **must confirm** that you understand your legal rights as a J-1 Exchange Visitor in the United States. Know these rights before your interview.

RIGHT 1

FAIR TREATMENT

You have the right to be treated legally and to be paid at least the prevailing wage for your field. Underpayment or off-the-books arrangements are illegal.

RIGHT 2

ID OWNERSHIP

You have the absolute right to keep your own passport and ID documents. Employers and host companies under any circumstance.

RIGHT 3

ABUSE REPORTING

You have the right to report any abuse — labor, sexual, financial, or otherwise — without fear of deportation, retaliation, or program termination.

RIGHT 4

RIGHTS PAMPHLET

You must verify to the officer that you have read the U.S. Department of State's "Rights and Protections" pamphlet. Read it before your interview.

I IF YOU NEED HELP IN THE U.S.

If you experience workplace abuse, passport seizure, unpaid wages, or any threat to your safety: contact your CTI Reporting Contact immediately, contact your Sponsor's emergency line, and if urgent, dial 911. The National Human Trafficking Hotline (1-888-373-7888) operates 24/7 and is confidential.

DOCUMENTS TO BRING ON INTERVIEW DAY

Bring originals plus one photocopy of each. Carry in a clear plastic folder. **Do NOT put any of these in checked luggage.**

- ☐ **Passport** — valid for at least 6 months beyond your intended stay.
- ☐ **DS-2019 Form** — original eligibility document from your Sponsor.
- ☐ **DS-7002** — detailed Training Plan.
- ☐ **SEVIS I-901** — proof of SEVIS fee payment.
- ☐ **DS-160 confirmation** — printed page with barcode.
- ☐ **Financial proof** — liquid bank statements (last 6 months).
- ☐ **Offer letter** from your Host Company, on letterhead.
- ☐ **Return-intent documents** — letters of intent, university acceptance, property docs.
- ☐ **Photo** — passport-style, U.S. visa specifications.
- ☐ **Indonesian National ID (KTP).**

POST-APPROVAL PROCEDURES

STEP 1

PASSPORT RETURN

Typically couriered to you in **3-10 business days** after approval.

STEP 2

STAMP CHECK

Verify your **Name, DOB, and SEVIS ID** on the visa stamp for typos. Report any error to CTI immediately.

STEP 3

TRAVEL

Book flights **ONLY after** you have received your passport and verified the stamp.

! DS-160 CRITICAL FAIL

Save your DS-160 Application Number immediately upon starting the form. **It cannot be recovered.** If lost, your entire DS-160 data is permanently erased and you must restart from scratch.

THE DAY BEFORE YOUR INTERVIEW

- Sleep well. A tired Participant gives a poor impression.
- Lay out your interview clothes — professional, neutral, comfortable.
- Organize your documents per Section 11 in a clear plastic folder.
- Confirm your route to the embassy. Allow extra time.
- Re-read this packet once — but do NOT memorize answers.
- Confirm your social media profiles are public (72-hour rule, Section 9).
- Switch off your phone before entering the embassy. Better: leave it behind.

✓ THREE THINGS TO REMEMBER

- **Be honest.** Every answer, every document, every form.
- **Be specific.** Specific facts beat general statements every time.
- **Be calm.** The interview is 2-3 minutes. The officer is professional. You have prepared.

YOUR NOTES

Use the space below to write the key facts you want to be sure of. **Write in your own words.** Do not draft sentences to recite.

MY SPONSOR (CIEE / ALLIANCE ABROAD / GREENHEART)

MY HOST COMPANY — LEGAL NAME, CITY, STATE, ROLE, SUPERVISOR

MY RETURN-INTENT ANCHORS — WHAT IS TRUE FOR ME

YOU'VE GOT THIS

Support 24/7 · compliance@cti-usa.com · www.cti-usa.com